



VIETNAM

Capital city: Hanoi**Area:** 127,243 sq miles
(329,560 sq km)**Population:** 81,400,000**Official language:**
Vietnamese**Major religions:** Buddhist
55%, Christian 7%, other
38%**Government:** One-party
state**Currency:** Dong**Adult literacy rate:** 93%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 1,919**Televisions:** 47 per 1,000
people

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EVERY DAY FOR 13 YEARS Vietnam appeared on television sets and in newspapers around the world as the communist-led north of the country fought the American-backed south in a vicious war. When the war ended in 1975, with victory for the north, Vietnam had been devastated by the years of fighting and many of its people wanted to leave. Although the communist government struggled for years to recover, its policy of allowing foreign firms to invest in new industries slowly strengthened the economy. Today, tourists are beginning to visit this beautiful country in ever greater numbers. Despite this success, most people in Vietnam remain very poor.



RUSH HOUR ON A BICYCLE

Cars dominate most large cities in the world, but in Vietnam the bicycle rules the road. Everyone has a bicycle that they use to get to work or for shopping, because few people are rich enough to afford a car. In the morning and evening rush hours, streets like this one in Ho Chi Minh City are packed with cyclists, ringing their bells and shouting out loud to warn pedestrians and other cyclists to get out of the way.



THE BIRTH OF A CHILD

In the past, many Vietnamese babies did not live for long, so families did not celebrate the birth of a child, but rather its survival for a month. This ritual continues today. Later, when the child is a year old, the family celebrates *Thoi Noi*. The child is shown a tray with objects on it. Whichever one the child chooses shows which career he or she will follow – for example, a pen for a teacher, scissors for a tailor.

Most villages have an electricity supply, and some families own a television set.



House made of concrete

Outdoor shower

Plot for growing vegetables and corn



Many of the boat people died at sea from disease or because their boats were not strong enough for the hazardous voyage.

THE BOAT PEOPLE

After the end of the war, many Vietnamese people tried to leave in search of jobs abroad or out of fear of persecution. They took to the sea in boats, hoping to reach the West via Hong Kong, Malaysia, or Singapore. By 1980 about half a million people had set sail. The flood of refugees stopped when neighboring countries began to send them home.

RICE GROWING

Two-thirds of the farmland in Vietnam is under water for part of the year, but deliberately so, because the fields are flooded to grow rice. During the rainy season, the fields slowly fill with rainwater, which is kept in place by low earth dikes. Soon a series of shallow, muddy paddy fields appears. Women plant the rice by hand. It takes two to three months to grow to full strength and is then harvested.



VILLAGE LIFE

Four out of every five people in Vietnam live in the countryside. Because cars are rare, and there are few railroad lines, most of them will never visit the great cities of Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh. The vast majority live in small villages and earn their living as farmers or laborers. Here they live in simple houses made of concrete, brick, or, more traditionally, wood, straw, and palm leaves. A typical house has two rooms – one for eating and living, the other for sleeping – but no running water. Water comes from a well outside.



Families live on the fruits and vegetables they grow on their farms. They eat meat only on special occasions.

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